

Learning Objectives:

- Understand how board games can be used to prototype video game elements.
- Focus on mechanic design and challenge development.
- Understand how movement and actions are similar or different in a gameplay context.

Assignment:

- Build a physical board game prototype with your group
- It should reference or be inspired by a video game or video game mechanic.

If you need more direction, imagine a scenario where you have been hired by a video game company to create a physical prototype for testing and the goal is to encapsulate the core mechanic or experience of a video game into a physical board game.

Starting Resources:

You can use the Schmupp example game from last week as a starting point OR you can start from a simple starting point such as an empty board and build it up from there.

You are free to add or remove rules as you'd like, with a goal of making something simple, but with emergent depth later as the game progresses.

Process

You should loosely follow an iterative process like we outlined for the card game in A2, however you don't have to explicitly reference every single step like we did. What I would like for this assignment would be that for each change to the game, give a short summary of the changes, and include the reasoning behind it and visual examples (if needed).

Visual reference can be made in Figma, in physical board game prototypes and photos, or in some other way such as ai generation, or digital prototype.

Extra Notes: Digital Prototype

You can optionally model the game in a programming language to visualize or explore options, or to help with testing, however the final marked game must be a physical prototype and must be playable as a physical game, which is how it will be evaluated.

Submission Requirements and Deliverables:

Group Submission:

1. A physical prototype (e.g. made out of paper, tokens etc.) that is playable and measurable as a physical board game. I must be able to play it without printing out or creating any additional elements.
2. A digital version of the board game (in a PDF exported from Figma, or equivalent) for posterity and hand-in.
3. A rule card that clearly and efficiently explains the rules. This can be a digital PDF or physical printed card (or both).
4. An overview or summary document outlining your theme, thought process, laying out your reasoning for making key decisions, and demonstrating how you gathered and used feedback to iterate the design as a group. (~1-2 pages + graphics to demonstrate key points)

Individual Submission:

5. A reflection document, answering the reflection questions provided. (~2-3 pages + visuals).

Assignment Timeline:

Week 1: Oct 20th

Establish your theme, references, core mechanic, and starting board configuration.

Week 2: Oct 27th

Playtest and refine. Consider the challenges the player will face, evaluate the number and quality of gameplay options available, and iterate the design.

Week 3: Nov 3rd

Final polish and balancing. Identify different strategies that a player can take, try to remove dominant strategies and edge cases that break the gameplay, and balance different gameplay options to make sure they are interesting and engaging.

Due: Nov 8th, 2025 @ 11:59PM

Student Rubric Guide: 20 points (Group) + 10 points (Individual) = 30 Possible Points

Category 1: Project Execution – Art & Gameplay (20 points)

Art Cohesion & Principles (5 pts)

What this means: Your game should look visually consistent and use basic art principles like color, contrast, scale, and layout to support gameplay.

0	1-2	3	4	5
Placeholder art or no visual cohesion	Art feels mismatched or inconsistent.	Art is functional but lacks polish or intentional design.	Strong visual consistency and layout. Minor issues may exist.	Everything feels intentional and cohesive. You've used visual design to guide the player and support the game's identity.

Gameplay Progression and Challenge (5 pts)

What this means: Your game should have a clear progression, increasing challenge, and show evidence of playtesting and iteration. This means it should be easy to pick up and play, but still offer new challenges to advanced players that have played it many times.

0	1-2	3	4	5
Gameplay loop is broken or missing.	Gameplay is unclear or unbalanced.	Game is playable but lacks challenge or progression.	Gameplay is refined and balanced.	Gameplay evolves meaningfully. You've clearly adjusted based on feedback.

Examples:

- Add new obstacles or mechanics in later levels.
- Use feedback to fix confusing areas or improve pacing.

Technical Complexity & Functionality (Core Mechanics) (5 pts)

What this means: Your game should show depth in mechanics and systems. Your core systems should be simple, but elegantly designed and include emergent elements for full marks. Games that are too complex can also score lower in the category.

0	1-2	3	4	5
No working mechanics.	Mechanics are buggy or incomplete.	Basic mechanics work but are limited or gameplay is too complex and unwieldy.	Strong implementation of core mechanics.	Mechanic is both simple to start with, but deep and complex, with emergent elements.

Rules and Clarity (5 pts)

What this means: Your rules themselves should be clear, concise and easy to get started with.

0	1-2	3	4	5
Not provided	Rules are unclear or extremely complex.	Rules are functional but unclear, too complex or missing several steps or concepts.	Strong visual consistency and layout. Rules are clear and concise and the players can easily figure out the game mechanics.	Everything feels intentional and cohesive. You've used visual design to guide the player and support the game's identity.

Category 2: Individual Reflection, Documentation & Process (10 points)

Reflection Document – PRESENTATION (5 pts)

For full marks you should be bringing in critical discussion of your process and mechanic, referencing topics such as state spaces, branching factors, specific probability estimates and mechanic and challenge design principles. You should be providing specific visual example (e.g. in Figma docs) that demonstrate the principles you are talking about.

0	1-2	3	4	5
Not submitted.	Missing elements or poorly formatted.	All elements present but layout is basic or unclear. Vague references to class topics but requires further development.	Mostly polished and complete. Some graphics provided and explanation of key ideas is sometimes present.	Clean layout, branded tone, includes all required elements. Clearly ties your process to principles learned in class. Visual examples are plentiful and clear.

Pitch Document – WRITING (5 pts)

For full marks, the document should be free to grammatical and spelling errors, clearly written and include an introduction and conclusion. All points on the questionnaire and specifically and clearly answered and addressed. (Suggested length would be a short paragraph (3-4 sentences) per question.

0	1-2	3	4	5
Not submitted.	Some points missing or unclear.	Points are addressed but lack clarity or polish. Subjective statements are used as examples and lack analysis and depth.	Most points are well-written and clear. Points are sometimes backed up with specific examples or reference to topics.	Each of the key points is clearly and professionally written. Points are objectively written and backed up with game design theory principles.